처음 만난 사람과 나이 확인하기: 형? 언니? 선배?

This worksheet shows how age and seniority shape the way Koreans talk to and address each other.

WHAT THIS IS FOR

You can read short profiles and situations to find who is older and what people should call each other, and tell when it is polite to switch to casual speech.

1 FIRST MEETING: HOW AGE SETS THE WAY YOU TALK

1. **존댓말로 인사하기** (greet in polite speech)
2. **나이(년생) 묻기** (ask age or birth year)
3. **위아래 확인하기** (find out who is older)
4. **호칭 정하기** (decide what to call each other)
5. **말 놓기** (switch to casual speech, only if the older person suggests it)

2 WORDS FOR AGE AND RANK

1. **년생** (born in (year))
   Koreans often compare age by birth year.
   예: 저는 97년생인데, 민호 씨는요?
2. **동갑** (the same age)
   Same-age people often become friends quickly and use casual speech.
   예: 우리 동갑이네요! 편하게 지내요.
3. **연세** (age (honorific))
   Use this instead of 나이 for an older person's age.
   예: 할아버지는 연세가 많으셔도 매일 산책하세요.
4. **형 / 오빠** (older male (friend))
   A man calls an older man 형. A woman calls an older man 오빠.
   예: 형, 오늘 점심 같이 먹어요.
5. **누나 / 언니** (older female (friend))
   A man calls an older woman 누나. A woman calls an older woman 언니.
   예: 언니, 이 옷 어때요?
6. **후배** (junior)
   Someone who started school or work after you.
   예: 제 후배가 이번에 우리 팀에 왔어요.
7. **동기** (same-year peer)
   People who entered school or a company in the same year. Their ages can be different.
   예: 나이는 달라도 우리는 입사 동기예요.
8. **막내** (the youngest)
   The youngest person in a family or group.
   예: 제가 우리 팀 막내예요.
9. **말을 놓다** (to drop polite speech)
   To start using casual speech with someone. The older person usually offers first.
   예: 우리 이제 말 놓을까요?

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3 DIFFERENT FROM YOUR COUNTRY?

In many countries, asking someone's age feels too personal. In Korea, it is a normal question at a first meeting, because age decides your speech level and what you call each other.
At work, your job title matters more than your age. A younger manager is still 팀장님. Keep using 존댓말 with older people until they suggest 말 놓기.

Customs about age and titles can be different for each person and workplace, so follow what the other person prefers.

4 YOUR TURN

FIND, CHOOSE, AND DECIDE
Use the words and tips on page 1 to answer each question.

1 Choose the right title:
①도윤 씨(남자)가 한 살 많은 남자에게 (형 / 오빠)
②하린 씨(여자)가 두 살 많은 여자에게 (언니 / 누나)
③태민 씨(남자)가 세 살 많은 여자에게 (언니 / 누나)

2 Fill in the blank with the polite word for age:
저희 할머니는 올해 ____가 여든이세요.

3 Choose the right word (선배 / 후배 / 동기):
①저보다 1년 늦게 입학한 사람은 제 ____예요.
②저와 같은 해에 입사한 사람은 제 ____예요.

4 Read the club list and answer in Korean:
수아 03년생, 준호 01년생, 민지 03년생, 현우 05년생.
①수아 씨와 동갑인 사람은 누구예요?
②이 동아리의 막내는 누구예요?

5 Is it polite? Write Yes or No:
①38살 신입 사원이 34살 팀장을 '팀장님'이라고 불러요.
②처음 만난 날, 나이가 어린 사람이 먼저 '우리 말 놓자.'라고 해요.

✓ ANSWERS

1) ① 형 ② 언니 ③ 누나
2) 연세
3) ① 후배 ② 동기
4) ① 민지 (민지 씨) ② 현우 (현우 씨)
5) ① Yes ② No

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